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A

abba

Abba is the Aramaic word for “father.” Aramaic was the language that the people in Israel spoke in Jesus’s time. Jesus calls God “abba” when he prays to God just before he was arrested and then crucified. Paul later wrote in his letters that the Holy Spirit makes us say “abba, father!” to God. This means that because of the Holy Spirit, we can have the same intimate relationship with God as a child has with its father- just as Jesus had.

abba

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Abraham

Abraham was the first ancestor of the Israelites, the Jews. Abraham’s name had been Abram, but God later changed his name to Abraham. Abraham means “the father of many nations.”

Abraham lived about two thousand years before the birth of Jesus. He first lived in a region named Ur, which was somewhere east of Israel. Abraham’s father Terah took his sons and their wives with him and left Ur, because he wanted to go to the country named Canaan, but he stopped in a place called Haran. This was still quite far away from Canaan. The family began to live there, and after some time Abraham’s father died. Abraham and his family did not know God; they worshiped idols.

When Abraham was 75 years old, God spoke to him. God told him to leave behind his homeland, and to go to a place that God would show him. God said that he would bless Abraham, that he would make a great nation out of him, and that God would bless all the nations of the world through Abraham. And Abraham obeyed God! Together with his wife Sarah and his nephew Lot he set out on a long journey. When he came to Canaan, God told him that this was the country that he would give to Abraham and to his descendants.

However, Abraham did not have any descendants yet. He had no children, and he was already an old man! But he believed God’s promise. And God was very pleased with Abraham’s trust, and therefore he accepted Abraham as someone with whom God could have a good relationship.

But Abraham still had to wait for a long time before God gave him any descendants. He had to wait 25 more years, and during that time he made several mistakes and sometimes forgot to trust God. But eventually, when Abraham was 100 years old and his wife Sarah was 90 years old, Sarah gave birth to a son. How happy Abraham and Sarah were then! And they called their son “Isaac,” which means laughter.

Then, after some years, God gave Abraham a very difficult test. God told Abraham that he had to sacrifice his son Isaac. He had to kill Isaac, and burn him as a gift for God! But by now Abraham had really learned to trust God, and he obeyed. And when Abraham had already lifted his knife to kill his son, God stopped him and praised Abraham! And God said that because Abraham had shown that he really trusted God and had obeyed him, now the blessing that God had promised to give to Abraham would continue also for Isaac, and Abraham’s further generations. Through Abraham’s descendants all the people of the world would be blessed!

And so, Isaac grew up and had two sons. The youngest son was Jacob. Jacob’s name was later changed to Israel. Jacob, or Israel, had 12 sons. The descendants of these 12 sons became the 12 tribes of Israel. They became a big nation. And one of their descendants was Jesus! And through Jesus, all the people of the world are blessed. God has fulfilled his promise to Abraham!

Abraham

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adonai

The word **Adonai** is a word in the Hebrew language, which is the language of the Old Testament. Adonai means lord, or master. The Jews often use this word as a respectful title to talk about God.

adonai

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adultery

Adultery is a form of sexual sin. God considers it a sin whenever people have a sexual relationship with someone to whom they are not married, but in the Old Testament the word adultery is used for a specific case. If a man has sexual relations with a woman who was married to someone else, both the man and

woman are guilty of adultery. The punishment for adultery is death. However, if the woman is raped, only the man had to die.

When a man had sexual relations with an unmarried woman or slave, he had still disobeyed, or sinned, against God, but according to the Old Testament law, this sin is not in the category of adultery.

God hates adultery and every form of sexual sin. God often compares the disobedience of people to himself with adultery: When people are unfaithful to God and begin to worship idols and false gods, they are behaving just like a man and a woman who are unfaithful to their own husband or wife. Therefore, God calls idolatry-the worship of idols or of any other god besides God himself-a form of adultery.

In the New Testament, Jesus made the rules about adultery more strict. He said that if someone only thought about having a sexual relationship with someone they are not married to, this is already sin.

adultery

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advocate

An **advocate** is someone who speaks on behalf of another person. An advocate wants people to help a person or group of people in trouble and to treat that person or group of people fairly. For example, if someone speaks to the government of the country and asks if the government can do more to help the poor people, he is advocating for the poor people.

In a court case, an advocate defends the person who people have accused of doing a crime. The advocate may say to the judge that the person is innocent and doesn't deserve punishment, or the advocate may tell the court that the person is really sorry for what he has done, or that he didn't mean to do it. An advocate tries to get the judge to give only a very mild punishment, or to give no punishment at all.

advocate

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altar

An **altar** is a place where people make offerings or sacrifices to God. It is like a table or a platform that people make of earth or large stones. People placed gifts for God on this table. Often this meant that people then burned the gift. The gift could be an animal, or could be food items, or sweet smelling spices.

Before the Israelites built the tabernacle and the temple, the Israelites built altars in different places. After God had told them to make the tabernacle, the Israelites were only supposed to build altars in the tabernacle, and later in the temple.

Other people groups besides the Israelites also made altars to give offerings to their own gods.

altar

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amen

Amen is an Hebrew word. Depending on when it is used, it can mean something like, "I accept this," "May it be true," "Indeed," or "Truly."

When someone tells you that something good is going to happen, you can respond by saying "Amen!" This means that you say that you hope and believe that it will be true.

When someone offers a prayer to God, you can say "Amen." This means that you hope and believe that the prayer will be answered.

Jesus uses the word amen in a different way. Jesus often says "Amen" or even "Amen, amen" at the beginning of his teaching. When Jesus says "Amen," he means: "Listen carefully to what I'm going to say, because it is true and very important."

amen

Audio Content
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angel

An **angel** is a supernatural, spiritual being created by God. Angels give messages from God to people; for instance, an angel told Mary that she would be pregnant through the power of God. Sometimes an angel gives a message to people in a dream; for instance, an angel told Joseph in a dream to take Mary and Jesus and flee to Egypt.

Sometimes an angel seems to look like a normal person, but at other times, angels can look very bright and shining, or even frightening. Often, the first thing they had to say to people was "do not be afraid!"

An angel can also do a specific task for God. They can help people or protect them; for instance, a whole

army of angels stood around the prophet Elisha when the Aramaean king tried to capture him.

God also uses angels to give punishments to people. For instance, an angel killed the firstborn sons in Egypt after the king refused to let the Israelites leave. From the New Testament we know that God will use angels for his final judgment.

Another very important task for angels is to worship God. We find this especially in the book of Revelation.

An important type of angel is an archangel. This is an angel with special authority. The Bible mentions two archangels by name: Gabriel and Michael.

Not all angels stayed obedient to God. Some angels rebelled. They became evil spirits, and the name of their leader is Satan.

When translating the word "angel," be careful about following things:

Make sure people will not get confused with the word you have chosen for "prophet." A prophet also gives messages from God to the people, but a prophet is a human person, belonging to earth, while an angel is a supernatural being, belonging to heaven.

angel

Audio Content
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angel of the Lord

An angel is a supernatural, spiritual being created by God. Angels give messages from God to people. The "angel of the Lord" or "angel of Yahweh" is a special angel who speaks with so much authority that it is as if God himself is speaking. Normally people would die if they saw God face to face, so it could even be that this angel is God himself, but appearing to people in a way that they can see Him and survive! People are often afraid when they see an angel of the Lord, because he usually looks awesome. We do not hear about this kind of angel of the Lord or angel of Yahweh in the New Testament, because he is no longer needed. God is now speaking directly through Jesus.

angel of the Lord

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anoint

To **anoint** someone means to pour sweet smelling oil over someone. You can also anoint an object.

In the Old Testament, before God gave someone a special task, he would instruct someone else to pour oil over that person's head. The oil was a symbol for the Holy Spirit of God. This ritual made clear that God had set this person apart for a special purpose. It also made clear that God was giving this person special authority. The person was then called "anointed." For instance, God told Samuel to anoint David as king of Israel. God told Moses to anoint Aaron as high priest. And God told the prophet Elijah to anoint Elisha as a prophet to succeed Elijah.

Later, the word "anointed" was also used for people whom God had appointed for a special task, even if there had not been a ritual that involved the pouring of oil. Jesus is called "the anointed," because God has selected him for a very special task.

People could also anoint objects. The priests anointed the objects that were used in the temple with oil to make clear that they now had a special purpose. These objects now belonged to God; they were sacred.

Jewish people also used anointing as a daily activity that had no special meaning. They used sweet smelling oil to take care of their skin and their hair. Jesus told the people that if they fasted, they should anoint themselves just as they did every day, rather than make themselves look unkempt so that other people could think, "These people are fasting, how impressive!"

People also put some oil on guests to show them they were welcome and honored. There are two stories in the Gospels of women putting oil on Jesus's feet to honor him.

Jewish people also anointed a person's body after his death. After Jesus died, the women are bringing sweet smelling oil to the tomb in order to anoint Jesus's body.

In the New Testament, the early Christians sometimes used oil together with prayer if someone was sick. The apostle James, in his letter, says that if someone is sick, the other believers should pray for the person and anoint the person with oil. This was not because the oil had any special power, but because it was a symbol of God's presence.

anoint

Audio Content
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anoint

People **anointed** dead bodies to show people honor and to help the decomposing bodies smell better. Women would mix sweet-smelling spices with oil and rub that into the cloth or body of the dead person.

anoint

Audio Content
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anoint

When people **anoint** an object or a place, they are pouring oil or wine over the object or place. They do this to dedicate the object or place to God. In the Old Testament, Jacob had a vision of God while he was sleeping with his head on a stone. When he woke up, he anointed this stone with oil to mark this place as holy, because God had spoken to him there. When the people of Israel had made the tabernacle, the priests anointed the objects in the tabernacle to dedicate them to God. These objects were now sacred, or holy, and would be used only for special service of worship to God.

anoint

Audio Content
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apostle

In the Gospels, Jesus chooses 12 disciples. But even in the Gospels these disciples are sometimes called **apostles**. In the book of Acts, these same people, along with some others, are now called apostles. What is the difference?

A disciple means someone who is committed to follow Jesus. This doesn't mean that only the 12 disciples were disciples. Disciples are all people who follow Jesus and who are learning from him.

An apostle is someone who has received a special authority from Jesus. An apostle is appointed. An apostle is speaking on behalf of Jesus.

In the Gospels, the 12 disciples are sometimes called apostles, especially when Jesus is sending them out to do something. But in the book of Acts, the 12 disciples are always called apostles. This makes clear that now they have authority. Jesus has given them the task to continue the work that he started. They are not doing their own work; they are doing the work of Jesus.

This is the work that an apostle is supposed to do:

1. An apostle is a witness to other people that Jesus really had risen from the dead. The apostles had been with Jesus, they knew that he had really died, and they had seen him after he became alive again. So they are able to tell other people that this is really true.
2. An apostle preaches the gospel to all people and establishes churches.
3. An apostle has authority in the church. God had given the apostles the authority to make decisions about spiritual matters. They are the representatives of Jesus in the church. God had also given them power to do miracles. This was proof for other people that their authority really came from God.

apostle

Audio Content
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ark of the covenant

The **ark of the covenant** was a rectangular chest that skilled Israelite craftsmen made from acacia wood and covered with gold inside and out. The ark of the covenant was not a boat, like Noah's ark. The ark of the covenant was about 115 centimeters long, 69 centimeters wide, and 69 centimeters high. The craftsmen attached four gold rings at the bottom corners of the ark and inserted poles so the Levites could carry the ark without touching it. The craftsmen made a lid for the ark of the covenant from pure gold. The Israelites sometimes called the lid "the mercy seat" or "the atonement cover." The craftsmen also made two golden cherubim and placed these on top of the mercy seat. Cherubim are spiritual beings who do the will of Yahweh. The cherubim faced each other and spread their wings over the lid. Moses placed the stone tablets of the law inside the ark. The ark may have also held a jar of manna and Aaron's staff.

The Israelites' skilled craftsmen made the ark of the covenant while the Israelites were wandering in the desert. Once the Israelites made the ark, they kept it in the Most Holy Place inside the tabernacle. The priests and Levites were the only Israelites who could touch the poles of the ark to move it. After King Solomon built the temple of Yahweh, the priests moved the ark into the Most Holy Place in the temple. Some Bible scholars believe that someone moved the ark of the covenant before the Babylonians destroyed the first

temple of Yahweh, but other scholars believe that the Babylonians destroyed the ark of the covenant.

The ark of the covenant symbolized four things: Yahweh's covenant with the Israelites, Yahweh's presence with the Israelites, Yahweh's power, and Yahweh's mercy. First, the ark symbolized Yahweh's covenant with the Israelites. A covenant is a sacred agreement between two parties who promise to help one another and be loyal to one another. The law, which Moses wrote on stone tablets, showed the Israelites what they needed to do to be loyal to Yahweh. This is why Yahweh told Moses to put the stone tablets of the law into the ark.

When Yahweh made the covenant with the Israelites, Yahweh said that the Israelites would be Yahweh's people and he would be their God. Yahweh promised that his presence would always be with the Israelites. So the second thing that the ark of the covenant represented was Yahweh's presence with the Israelites. Yahweh said that he was literally present on the mercy seat of the ark of the covenant. The Israelites sometimes talked about the mercy seat like it was Yahweh's throne. A throne is a large, beautiful chair that a king sits on. The ark of the covenant, especially the mercy seat, is the place where Yahweh's presence was on earth.

Yahweh is all-powerful. Wherever Yahweh is, Yahweh's power is with him. So the third thing that the ark of the covenant represented was Yahweh's power. This is why the Israelites often carried the ark into battle with them. Miraculous things happened everywhere the ark went, because the ark represented Yahweh's power.

Fourth, the ark represented Yahweh's mercy. Yahweh called the lid of the ark "the mercy seat." Every year on the Day of Atonement, the high priest came into the Most Holy Place and sprinkled the blood of the sacrifice in front of the ark and on the mercy seat. The Israelites received Yahweh's mercy when Yahweh forgave their sins.

Storytellers in the Bible usually call this golden chest the ark of the covenant, but sometimes they call it the ark of God, the ark of Yahweh, the holy ark, the ark of power, the testimony or the ark of testimony. In this context, the word "testimony" means the law that Moses wrote on the stone tablets. This law "testifies," or shows the truth that Yahweh has a special covenant with the people of Israel. We sometimes call the ark of the covenant the "covenant box."

ark of the covenant

Audio Content
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atonement

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During the time of the Old Testament, when someone did something bad to somebody else, people believed that three things would happen. First, people believed that the relationship between the two people would be broken. Second, people believed that the bad thing that the person did would make that person and their surroundings spiritually dirty. Third, people believed that God would notice the spiritual dirt and punish the person who did the bad thing.

Atonement fixed all three of these problems. Atonement would restore the broken relationship between the two people. Atonement would cleanse the person and their surroundings from the bad thing that made them spiritually dirty. Because the person was cleansed from the bad thing he or she did, God would not punish the person.

If people did something bad to another human, they would usually give a gift to the person they had done something bad to in order to atone for what they did. If people did something bad to Yahweh, they would give Yahweh a gift of an animal sacrifice to atone for what they did. Yahweh said that the blood of the animal would cleanse the person who had done the bad thing. Being spiritually clean would restore that person's good relationship with Yahweh, and so Yahweh would not punish the person for the bad thing that he or she did.

In the New Testament, Jesus came to atone for all the bad things that everyone has done. Because Jesus never did anything bad, Jesus did not need to atone for anything. But Jesus chose to die so that Jesus' blood could atone for the bad things that everyone else did. Now, if people choose to become Jesus's followers, Jesus's blood atones for all the bad things those people did against Yahweh. That means that Jesus's blood cleanses people from the spiritual dirt that covers them and makes people clean again. Being spiritually clean restores people's good relationship with Yahweh. Because Jesus's followers are now spiritually clean and have a good relationship with Yahweh, Yahweh will not send them to eternal punishment for what they have done.

atonement

Audio Content
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authority

Someone who has **authority** has the right and the power to make decisions and judgments. The highest authority belongs to God. God can give authority to other people to make decisions or judgments on his behalf. God will often show that he has given authority to people by also giving them power to do miracles.

Jesus has authority because he is the king, and God sent him.

The apostles had authority in the church, because Jesus gave it to them. Other people needed to accept their decisions.

The Bible has authority because God is speaking to the people through the Bible. This means that people have to listen to what God tells them through the Bible.

authority

Audio Content
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